

Brown's hard work pays off

By VINCE LANGFORD
Times Staff Writer

It was not Steve Brown's night to pitch but it was not a night off. A few minutes before game time he was doing sit-ups. Andy Cohen took notice.

"That's the price of success," said Cohen admiringly. He might know, since the former major league player and coach in a half-century of professional baseball has seen those who succeeded spectacularly and those who failed miserably.

Why has Steve Brown, a 6-foot-5 right-hander, succeeded as a pitcher for the El Paso Diablos, a franchise which has catapulted a truckload of hitters into the major leagues but few starting pitchers?



Steve Brown

Why has Brown been so consistent almost every time he takes the mound, while other Diablo starters are as consistent as a roller-coaster?

"What I've noticed," Diablo Manager Jim Saul analyzed after a recent Brown victory, "and this goes along with a person's makeup, is that he's been changing speeds real well. He's willing to use his changeup to get out in front and then bust the fast ball by them."

"He was throwing as hard in the ninth as he was at the start of the game. That's a sign of a good pitcher, that shows me that the man is in shape."

"It tells me something about a man."

Mechanics aside, the mental is Brown's strength. "You've got to be hungry out there," Saul says of a pitcher's best ally.

"I just wish two or three other guys we have would take heed," Saul adds.

The greening of Steve Brown from

thrower to pitcher followed a red-faced initiation to the Diablos and the Texas League.

His stats in his first month last season with the Class AA Diablos after his escalation from Class A were a mid-summer nightmare: a 0-4 won-lost record, a 9.85 earned run average, 50 hits in 28 innings.

And those figures included a 2-1 loss in his first outing. Welcome to Class AA.

Suddenly last summer, however, Steve Brown went from bad to brilliant.

On Aug. 4, he won his first game, pitching a four-hit, 5-2 complete-game victory over the San Antonio Dodgers. On Aug. 18, he threw a nine-hit, 9-4 complete-game triumph over the Midland Cubs. Aug. 28 — a four-hit, 7-1 complete-game win over Midland.

On Sept. 2, the season finale, he took a bow with a five-hit, 14-strikeout, 6-3 complete-game win over Amarillo.

He renewed old acquaintances this season: April 11, eight innings, seven
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